

Feature Writing

Invitational B Meet • 2026



You are a reporter for the **Leaguetown Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School.

From the given information, write a **feature story** as you would for the high school newspaper. You may use statements attributed to individuals as **direct or indirect quotes**. You may not change the meaning of a statement. You have **one hour**.

Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Leaguetown High School has 1,072 students in grades 9-12. Bus driver Joanie Olsen has driven Bus 8 for five years. Her routes include 28 middle school students and 24 high school students. She drives more than 70 miles each day and more when she does field trips.

Last year, Olsen noticed that when it turned cold, many of her students would wait outside at the bus stop with no coat, hat or gloves. Her favorite hobby is knitting, so she decided this year, she would provide handmade hats for her students. She spent hours knitting four dozen hats of various styles and colors. When students stepped onto their bus the morning of Feb. 1, each received a new handmade hat from their bus driver.

For several students she had known for years, Olsen knitted specific designs and colors she knew they would like. One student loves the Dallas Cowboys, so his hat was silver and blue with a white star. Another student's favorite color is green, so Olsen knitted a striped hat with multiple shades of green. Other students could choose their own hat from the group.

One student, freshman Cristina Sanchez, was so impressed with the gift that she convinced Olsen to offer students a knitting class at the Leaguetown Recreation Center on the weekends. Classes are \$25 per month, but Olsen said she would cover the cost for any student in the district who wants to attend.

The first class will be Saturday, Feb. 21, at 9 a.m. Participants can sign up on the recreation center website. You are writing for the issue of the Press to be distributed Feb. 18.

■ JOANIE OLSEN, bus driver

"The week temperatures got down into the 20s last year, I picked up kids with no coats and no hats or gloves. They were lucky if they had a sweatshirt on to keep warm. I just shook my head and turned the heat up on the bus to help those kids keep warm.

"Then last Christmas, I gave a knitted hat to each of my nieces and nephews — about 10 total. I became pretty fast at making them, so I decided to make one for each of my bus kids the following year. So that's what I did. I don't want any kids to be without but especially any kid who's riding with me. I want my kids warm and comfy when our bus pulls up to school. It takes me about an hour or two to knit each one, depending on what kind of yarn and how detailed the design is. I started over the summer and by the time winter came, I had a hat for each kid and then some. I'm not interested in selling hats or anything like that. I just want to be able to provide something for kids who need them.

"Now that each kid has a hat, I'm making other things for kids who want them, like mittens or ponchos. I don't want anyone to be without something if they're cold. Even if they don't want to wear it, I want kids to know that when

■ JOANIE OLSEN, continued

they get on my bus, they're loved. When they get on Bus 8, they're going to hear 'Good morning,' and they're going to feel safe and loved.

"I've been knitting since I was 12, so by now, I'm pretty well stocked up with any color yarn you could imagine. I buy it at craft stores when it's 80% off. At this point, they barely cost anything to make. I have a craft room, but if I'm being honest, it's more of a yarn storage room. I'm looking forward to teaching the classes. It'll help me get rid of some of my old yarn, and maybe if I share my passion with other people, they can share a little warmth with others, too."

■ DONALD STERLING, sophomore

"I don't look at the weather before I get dressed every day, and all my clothes are athletic shorts and hoodies. I just don't think about it. It's been so cold a couple days, though. One morning, I got to the bus stop like 20 minutes early, and my body physically hurt because I was so cold. The next Monday, Miss Joanie had a Dallas Cowboys hat for me. I couldn't believe she had made it. It looked like something you would buy at a nice store. I could see how proud she was to give it to me. We both teared up as I stepped on the bus and headed toward my seat. Then I watched her offer a hat to every kid at every stop.

"Sometimes it feels like adults at school only talk to us if it's something negative — like I better hurry and get to class during a passing period or don't forget to throw away trash in the cafeteria. I love seeing Miss Joanie first thing in the morning because she treats us like real people. She even remembered I was a Dallas Cowboys fan. It's good to know we have adults at school who care about us like that."

■ CRISTINA SANCHEZ, freshman

"The hats she gave us are actually cute. Mine was pink with a huge poof ball at the top. I would have paid money for it. I don't know exactly how she does it, but it looks like professional work. I plan to sign up for her knitting class. I'm not involved in any clubs or after school activities, so maybe if I practice and dedicate enough time to learning, I can start a small business with her help.

"When I started riding the bus in middle school, I was worried the driver would be kind of mean or scary. This is my third year riding with Miss Joanie. I feel lucky to be on her bus. I've learned a lot by talking to her about knitting, not just about her hobby, but also about how to be a generous person."

■ DR. MARGARET CAMPBELL, superintendent

"She's the first face the kids see when they head to school every morning. I can't think of a better person to fill that role for these students. We certainly don't expect our bus drivers to put in so many extra hours for our students, but this district takes pride in hiring employees who care about kids. This is a prime example of that. I think if you look closer at many of our teachers, administrators, school nurses, cafeteria and custodial staff, you'll see the same thing."

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST!

Invitational B Meet • 2026 Feature Writing Contest Tips and Sample Story

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critiquing/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judge.

1. Figure out what the story is about and its theme or focus. This story is about a bus driver who gave handmade knitted hats to her students.
2. The lead of a feature story must grab the reader's attention. It does not have to be a certain length or include the 5Ws and H. It should set a scene and get the reader into the story. Although you have freedom to describe the scene as you think it might have existed, try to stay close to the prompt. Judges will not want you to wander off the subject too much.

The students who ride Bus 8 are keeping warm this winter, all thanks to a handmade gift from a friendly face — their bus driver.

When Joanie Olsen noticed students on her bus route waiting at the bus stop in below freezing temperatures with no hat, gloves or coat, she applied her favorite hobby to knit four dozen handmade hats for her middle and high school students. When students stepped onto the bus Feb. 1, they received their very own creation, one that would help them stay warm on a cold day.

3. Once you get past the lead, make sure you include a nut graph. It tells the reader what the story will be about. Follow the nut graph with a direct quote and then go into the transition/quote formula. In this story, the news peg is in the lead, but additional information is required.

nut graph

Now, Olsen will share her skills with others when she offers her first knitting class at the Leaguetown Recreation Center Saturday.

direct quote

“I don’t want any kids to be without, but especially any kid who’s riding with me,” she said. “I want my kids warm and comfy when our bus pulls up to school.”

4. After the nut graph, the rest of the story can tell itself through the use of transition/quote formula. Be sure you attribute after the quote or at least after the first sentence. An attribution should be: subject of attribution followed by the verb of attribution (“Olsen said” not “said Olsen”). Avoid putting two or more quotes together without placing some kind of transition between them. Also, make sure transitions provide information to help the action of the story and that the quote does not repeat information in the transition.

transition/story-telling

Olsen, who began knitting when she was 12, got the idea to knit hats for her students when she gifted some to her 10 nieces and nephews. She stockpiles different types and colors of yarn by purchasing it on sale from craft stores.

direct quote

“At this point, they barely cost anything to make, she said. “I have a craft room, but if I’m being honest, it’s more of a yarn storage room. I’m looking forward to teaching the classes. It’ll help me get rid of some of my old yarn, and maybe if I share my passion with other people, they can share a little warmth with others, too.”

5. Always use third person. Don’t say “your students” or “our students.” Also, do not editorialize. For instance, you should not say “Go Miss Joanie!” These statements are personal opinions and should not be used in a feature story.

6. Always use the verb “said” as the verb of attribution. Don’t say “says,” “stated,” “feels” or any other synonym for “said.”

7. Finally, look for a strong quote to use as a closing statement or a statement that will bring the reader back to the beginning of the story. It should give the reader a sense of satisfaction or resolution.

Olsen’s knitting classes are \$25 per month, but she said she would cover the cost of participation for any student to attend. She also plans to expand her gift-giving to mittens and warm ponchos for her students who need them.

“I don’t want anyone to be without something if they’re cold,” she said. “Even if they don’t want to wear it, I want kids to know that when they get on my bus, they’re loved. When they get on Bus 8, they’re going to hear ‘Good morning,’ and they’re going to feel safe and loved.”

SAMPLE STORY

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Now, Olsen will share her skills with others when she offers her first knitting class at the Leaguetown Recreation Center Saturday.

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“At this point, they barely cost anything to make,” she said. “I have a craft room, but if I’m being honest, it’s more of a yarn storage room. I’m looking forward to teaching the classes. It’ll help me get rid of some of my old yarn, and maybe if I share my passion with other people, they can share a little warmth with others, too.”

Olsen said each hat took around an hour to make, depending on the design. Some students even received a customized creation to fit their personality or interests.

“One morning, I got to the bus stop like 20 minutes early, and my body physically hurt because I was so cold,” sophomore Donald Sterling said. “The next Monday, Miss Joanie had a Dallas Cowboys hat for me. I could see how proud she was to give it to me. We both teared up as I stepped on the bus and headed toward my seat. Then I watched her offer a hat to every kid at every stop.”

Freshman Cristina Sanchez said she was so impressed with the quality of Olsen’s hats, she plans to sign up for the class and possibly start her own small knitting business.

“When I started riding the bus in middle school, I was worried the driver would be kind of mean or scary,” she said. “This is my third year riding with Miss Joanie. I feel lucky to be on her bus. I’ve learned a lot by talking to her about knitting, not just about her hobby, but also about how to be a generous person.”

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